

THE BIRYANI PROMISE

written by

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CHARACTERS

FATAK - a boy of twelve, who has never known a day without biryani
AMMA - his mother
RAVI - his friend, competitive, easily wounded by an unfair fielding order
MEENA - his friend, dry-witted, notices everything
GOPAL - watchman at the compound next door, unhurried, entirely without self-pity

SETTING

A quiet residential lane, and the homes that face each other across it. The present day, or near enough.

ACT ONE

1 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

1

A modest kitchen, warm with the smell of spices. A large pot simmers on the stove. AMMA, early forties, stirs it with the ease of long habit.

FATAK, twelve, hovers in the doorway, craning his neck toward the pot.

FATAK

Is it ready, Amma? It smells ready.

AMMA

(not turning around)
It smells ready every day. That doesn't mean it is.

FATAK

Today it smells more ready than usual.

AMMA

(a small laugh)
Wash your hands. By the time you're back it'll be on the table.

Fatak doesn't move. He edges closer, peering into the pot.

FATAK

Chicken biryani?

AMMA

When is it ever anything else, in this house.

FATAK

(grinning)
Just checking.

He hurries off. A beat later he's back, sliding into his chair as AMMA sets down a heaped plate -- rice glistening with ghee, dark with spice, a single piece of chicken resting on top like a small trophy.

FATAK (CONT'D)

(closing his eyes,
inhaling)

Every single day, and it still
smells like the first time.

AMMA

That's because I make it fresh. Not
everyone gets that.

FATAK

(already eating)

Lucky me.

They sit in comfortable quiet as Fatak eats -- not fast, not slow, the unhurried appetite of a boy who has never once had to wonder if there will be more.

AMMA

Leave room for your tea.

FATAK

(mouth full)

There's always room for tea.

A little later. The plate is empty. AMMA sets a small glass of tea in front of him, steam curling upward. Fatak wraps both hands around it, entirely content.

FATAK (CONT'D)

Best part of the day.

AMMA

You say that about the biryani too.

FATAK

(considering this
seriously)

It's a very good day. Every day.

He drains the last of the tea, sets the glass down with satisfaction, and heads off, schoolbag over one shoulder, already thinking of something else. This has happened every day for longer than either of them can properly remember.

2 EXT. FATAK'S HOUSE - STREET - EVENING

2

Golden light slants across a quiet lane. FATAK sits on the compound step, bouncing a tennis ball against the wall and catching it, again and again. Nothing to do, and enjoying it.

RAVI and MEENA round the corner. RAVI drags an old cricket bat behind him like a walking stick. MEENA carries three stumps under one arm.

RAVI

Fatak! Up, up, we're one man short.

FATAK

(springing up)

Where's Sameer?

MEENA

Tuition. His mother is very serious about fractions.

RAVI

(planting the stumps
against the wall)

Which means we need you. Catch practice first -- Sameer's not here to bowl.

FATAK

I'm always fielding first.

RAVI

Because you're always late.

FATAK

I was eating.

MEENA

(deadpan)

You are always eating.

FATAK

(entirely unbothered)

Biryani doesn't wait for cricket.
Cricket waits for biryani.

MEENA

(tossing the ball to Ravi)

Loosen up first. You always throw wild when you skip that part.

RAVI

(already winding up)

I'm warmed up.

He is not warmed up. He throws hard, aiming for Meena -- the ball sails high, wide, over the compound wall next door, and disappears.

A beat of stunned silence.

MEENA

That was Mr. Ilyas's compound.

RAVI

(losing enthusiasm fast)
That was Mr. Ilyas's compound.

They all look at Fatak.

FATAK

Why is everyone looking at me?

RAVI

You're standing closest to the gate.

Fatak looks at the gate. Looks back at his friends.

FATAK

(sighing, already walking)
Fine. But if there's a dog in there,
I'm blaming both of you at the
funeral.

He pushes through the half-open gate and disappears from view. RAVI and MEENA wait, unconcerned, already arguing about whether a lost ball cancels the throw.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

3 EXT. ILYAS COMPOUND - CONTINUOUS

3

A smaller, plainer yard. Washing hangs on a line. In the far corner, in the day's last stretch of shade, GOPAL -- fifties, wiry, the compound's watchman -- sits on an upturned crate. A steel plate rests on his knees: a small mound of plain white rice, one green chilli, nothing else.

He eats slowly. Unhurried. Each mouthful measured, as if he is making it last on purpose.

FATAK enters, scanning the ground, doesn't see him at first.

FATAK

(to himself)
It has to be somewhere...

He spots the ball -- rolled to a stop near Gopal's feet -- and stops short, seeing him.

Gopal looks up, unbothered, faintly amused by the intrusion.

GOPAL

Looking for this?

He nudges the ball toward Fatak with his foot, without rising, without breaking the rhythm of his meal.

FATAK

(quietly)
Yes. Sorry. My friend threw it a bit too well.

GOPAL

(a small smile)
It happens. That wall has seen worse.

Fatak bends to pick up the ball but doesn't leave. He's looking at the plate. The single chilli. The rice, going down mouthful by careful mouthful.

GOPAL (CONT'D)

(noticing, not unkindly)
Go on. Your friends are waiting.

FATAK

(a beat)
Is that -- all you're having?

GOPAL

(shrugging, without a trace of self-pity)
It's enough. Rice fills you up, if you eat it slowly.

He says it plainly, like a fact about the weather, and takes another unhurried mouthful.

FATAK

(not sure what to say)
Okay. Um -- thank you. For the ball.

GOPAL

(waving him off, kind)
Go. Play.

Fatak lingers a second longer than he means to, then turns and walks back toward the gate, ball in hand, moving slower than he came in.

4 EXT. FATAK'S HOUSE - STREET - CONTINUOUS

4

RAVI and MEENA are still arguing.

RAVI

It has to count. The ball left the field of play at maximum velocity --

MEENA

The ball left the field of play into somebody's dinner. That's not a rule anywhere.

They notice Fatak has returned. He hands Ravi the ball without a word.

RAVI

(taking it)

Finally. Okay -- who's batting --

FATAK

(quiet)

I think I'm done for today.

MEENA

(surprised)

You? Done playing? Before dinner?

FATAK

(half a smile, distracted)

See you tomorrow.

He walks back toward his house. RAVI and MEENA exchange a look, a shrug, and go back to arguing about the throw, already forgetting.

5 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - FATAK'S ROOM - NIGHT

5

Fatak lies on his back, eyes open, staring at the ceiling fan turning lazily above him. The house is quiet.

He turns onto his side. Turns back. Sits up.

FATAK

(to himself, barely
audible)

It's just rice.

He lies back down. The fan turns. He is very clearly not falling asleep.

FATAK (CONT'D)

(quieter still)

One chilli.

A long moment. Just the fan, and the boy, wide awake.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

6 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY (THE NEXT DAY)

6

The same table. The same plate -- rice glistening with ghee, a piece of chicken resting on top. AMMA sets it down the way she has every day for as long as Fatak can remember.

AMMA

Careful, it's hot.

Fatak sits. Looks at the plate. Doesn't move.

AMMA (CONT'D)

(pausing, noticing)

What?

FATAK

Nothing.

AMMA

You've stared at that plate for a full minute. That has never once happened in your life.

Fatak picks up his spoon. Sets it down again.

FATAK

Amma. Can I ask you something.

AMMA

(sitting across from him,
giving him her full
attention)

Always.

FATAK

Yesterday, when the ball went into Mr. Ilyas's compound -- I saw Gopal eating. Just rice. And one chilli.

AMMA

That's often what Gopal has. It's not new.

FATAK

It's new to me.

A silence. Amma doesn't rush to fill it.

FATAK (CONT'D)

I've sat here twelve years eating this, every single day, and it never once occurred to me to wonder what anyone else was eating. Not once.

AMMA

That doesn't make you a bad person.

FATAK

I know it doesn't. But I can't just eat like yesterday didn't happen. I keep doing the maths in my head and none of it fixes anything. Feeling bad about my plate doesn't make his any bigger.

AMMA

No. It doesn't.

FATAK

(the decision arriving as
he says it)

So I'm going to eat half. Starting
today. Half of what I usually eat
means the same biryani lasts twice
as long. I don't fully know yet what
that changes. But it has to change
something.

AMMA

(quiet)

And if it doesn't change anything
for Gopal?

FATAK

(a beat, honest)

Then it changes something in me. I
don't want to be someone who watches
a man eat one chilli and forgets by
dinner.

Amma looks at her son for a long moment. Then, without
another word, she reaches over and moves half the rice
from his plate back into the serving dish.

Fatak watches her do it. Doesn't stop her.

FATAK (CONT'D)

That's still a good plate.

AMMA

(throat tight, a small
smile)

It's a very good plate.

He picks up his spoon and eats -- slower than usual. Not
because there's less. Because for the first time, he's
paying attention.

7

EXT. FATAK'S HOUSE - STREET - EVENING (WEEKS LATER)

7

RAVI and MEENA set the stumps against the compound wall.
FATAK approaches, ball in hand -- the same ball.

RAVI

You're batting first today.
"Fielding first" is clearly rigged
against you, we're retiring it.

FATAK

(tossing the ball,
catching it)

Deal.

Meena glances toward the gate next door, where --
distantly, through the gap -- GOPAL can be seen settling
onto his crate with his evening plate.

MEENA

(quietly, to Fatak)
Sameer says you take forever over
lunch now. Is that why?

FATAK

(a small shrug, not making
a thing of it)
I just started paying attention.
That's all.

RAVI

(already bored of the
topic, but raised)
Can we play, or is this a serious
conversation.

FATAK

(grinning, tossing him the
ball)
We can play.

Fatak takes his position. Behind him, through the gate,
Gopal eats -- unhurried, same as always. Fatak doesn't
look back at him. He doesn't need to, anymore. He already
knows.

The game begins.

END OF PLAY